

Are you Addicted?

Internet Addiction Disorder (IAD) refers to pathological, compulsive Internet usage. The criteria for this disorder are similar to those for substance abuse disorders.

IAD is different from Pathological Computer Use (PCU), a condition where someone is pathological about any aspect of computers, and includes uses that are not social in their nature.

The following criteria were used for assessing IAD in a large initial study of this problem. If a person meets four or more of the 10 criteria, he can be diagnosed as suffering from IAD.

- Do you feel preoccupied with the Internet or online services and think about it while offline?
- Do you feel a need to spend more and more time online to achieve satisfaction?
- Are you unable to control your online usage?
- Do you feel restless when attempting to cut down or stop your online usage?
- Do you go online to escape problems or relieve feelings such as helplessness, guilt, anxiety or depression?
- Do you lie to conceal how often and how long you stay online?
- Do you risk losing a significant relationship, job, or educational or career opportunity because of your online use?
- Do you keep returning even after spending too much money on online fees?
- Do you go through withdrawal when offline, such as increased depression, moodiness, or irritability?
- Do you stay online longer than originally intended?

before instant messengers start to offer seamless connectivity. Platform, software and connectivity are all issues, which will sort themselves out soon. It's only a matter of time before computer, telephone and video technology will merge into one—perhaps highly addictive—beast.

Why the addiction

E-mail discussion groups, chat rooms, bulletin boards and MOOs (Object Oriented Multi User Dungeons) offer people an opportunity to experience a form of social contact and make virtual friends. But none of them match the industrial strength addictiveness of the GMUKS (graphical multi-user conversations). GMUKS, or visual chat in simple terms, are something of a cross between a MOO and a traditional chat room.

As social environments, GMUKS are unique in that they are graphical. Rather than limiting users to text-only communications as in most chat rooms, multimedia programs add a visual element that creates the illusion of movement, space, and physicality. It allows people to express themselves visually, rather than just through written words. The opportunities for self-expression and social interaction are much better, giving room for subtleties and complexities not seen in text-only chat rooms. One such haunt is the online multimedia community known as the 'Palace'. Combining features of MOOs and chat rooms, the Palace is a visual and spatial environment where members

nologies (telephones, mail, fax) is that the Internet allows for, and even encourages contact with, relative strangers. The probability of any real-life repercussions for online social activity is very low, and that makes people feel free to express themselves in an unrestrained manner. This is a naturally exciting, stimulating and reinforcing aspect of the Internet.

However, finding regular escape in cyberspace also has side effects—missed deadlines, lost jobs, low grades and loss of weight. It's only after you get unplugged that you realise the ramifications of this addiction, especially when they manifest themselves in the form of phone bills.

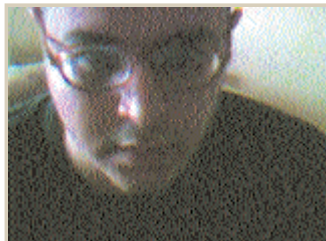
John Suler, PhD and faculty member in the Rider University Psychology department, has written some extensive papers on the psychology of cyberspace relationships. In his papers on Computer and Cyberspace Addiction, he writes, "A teenager who plays hooky from school in order to master the next level of Donkey Kong may be a very different person from the middle aged housewife who spends \$500 a month in AOL chat rooms—who in turn may be very different from the businessman who can't tear himself away from his finance programs and continuous Internet access to stock quotes. Some cyberspace addictions are game and competition oriented, some fulfil more social needs, and some simply may be an extension of workaholicism."

A person by the name Solz in #bookwarez (a channel in IRC) spoke at length about being a chat addict. "It's a wolf in sheep's clothing, really. Sure, it's fast. It's free. It's easy. You can leave it on all day if you have cable Internet like I do. Everyday, I wake up, I turn on my computer, I check my e-mail, and I sign onto Instant Messenger. Then I start chatting. It's an addiction, really. I have to, almost need to, be at my

computer when in its presence."

Chandrasekhar messages me in the wee hours of the night as I write, "You know what really sucks? You can't really make out anything about the person on the other end when you really want to, and you don't know if any of it is true. It freaks out paranoid people like me."

Net evangelist Howard Rheingold makes a good defence: "One might think the Net a cold place, and yet it need not be. In the impersonal isolation of our large cities, where people often live separated from kin or lonely amid the multitudes, the Net can become a surrogate social life—a vital source of interpersonal contact despite its non-physical nature. ■



Chandrasekhar
Pathological Net addict

Invisible says:

well, it wasn't really bad, it just prevents you from having a real life

Invisible says:

if you do it too much

invisible says:

but that applies to most things

interact with text, sounds, and graphical representations of themselves called 'avatars'.

GMUKS have had a huge impact on MMORPGs (Massively Multiplayer Online Role Playing Games) like *Everquest*, *Ultima Online*, and *Asheron's Call*. These games focus entirely on the social aspect of multiplayer gaming, and most of the time is passed making acquaintances and socialising. The team element is extremely vital to getting ahead; you have to partner up to destroy fire breathing dragons and monsters. It's the social aspect that makes the games so addictive.

Is the Web addictive or do addicts use the Web?

The significant difference between Net relationships and ones maintained by other existing tech-